

19 DECLINING CHRISTIANITY

Through the influence of the materialistic society in which we live, we have a declining rate of Christianity. Having Christian parents does not guarantee committed Christian children.

I do a great deal of traveling, and many times I'll get into a conversation with someone sitting next to me on an airplane. Eventually the conversation gets around to the subject that is most important to me: Jesus Christ. I'll ask, "Are you a Christian?" Conservatively, 90 percent of the people that I ask say that they are. It's interesting how some of them think people become Christians. Either their father used to be a pastor, they were baptized as a child, or their grandmother used to be a missionary. I often share with them, "Friend, you don't get to be a car by sitting in a garage, and you don't get to be a Christian by sitting in church."

You also don't get to be a Christian by growing up in a Christian family. Christian parents can influence their children a great deal, but the danger is that they will just learn the language. Then they'll be able to tell you what you want to hear, without it being real in their lives.

One of the things that I found with my children, and with others that I've counseled over the years, is there are signs and indicators that God has given that reveal true Christianity. If our children have no commitment to giving, it is either because they didn't get saved or they don't understand the lordship of Christ. A child of 12 or more who understands the lordship of Christ will give without parental pressure. Certainly early teaching is important, even critical, but at some point it must become *their* decision. When I find a Christian's offspring who doesn't give, I question: are they really saved, or are they only repeating what they were taught?

FINANCES: AN INDICATOR

In many children, I believe you can measure the level of their commitment to the Lord in part by the way that they handle their finances, especially how they respond to God's financial